

Irregular plural nouns

Some words just don't follow the rules. Although many nouns that end in -o are made plural by adding an s, others take the ending -es. Some nouns change their spelling completely when they become plural, while others do not change at all. Words that originate from Latin and Greek often have irregular plural endings. These exceptions have to be learned.



• If the plural form of a **noun** is used in a sentence, the **verb** that follows it must also be **plural**.

• Do not confuse **plural** words with the **possessive**. For example, "There are **two Jasons** [plural] in my class, and this is **Jason's car** [possessive]."

Singular
quiz

Plural
quizzes

Words ending in -f usually change their endings to -ves.

Words ending in -z usually take the regular -es ending.

Singular
belief
chief
cliff
roof

Plural
beliefs
chiefs
cliffs
roofs

Words ending in -o usually take the -s ending.

Singular
echo
hero
potato
tomato

Plural
echoes
heroes
potatoes
tomatoes

Singular
analysis
appendix
crisis

Plural
analyses
appendices
crises

Words of Latin or Greek origin often have irregular plural forms.

Some words change their spelling completely.

Singular
child
woman
person
man
foot
tooth
goose
mouse
ox

Plural
children
women
people
men
feet
teeth
geese
mice
oxen

Singular
sheep
deer
moose
series
scissors

Plural
sheep
deer
moose
series
scissors

Some words don't change at all.

Some nouns have two plural forms.

Singular
hoof
dwarf
mango
buffalo
index
focus

Plural
hooves or hoofs
dwarves or dwarfs
mangoes or mangos
buffaloes or buffalos
indexes or indices
focuses or foci

Staying singular

Collective nouns such as *flock* or *crowd* have plural forms, but usually appear in the singular. Some nouns do not have a plural form at all, even though they usually represent multiple things. Furniture, for example, is a singular word, but it may encompass a table, a chair, a sofa, and a cabinet.



education
information
homework
evidence
knowledge
weather
livestock
furniture



GLOSSARY

Collective noun The name given to a collection of individuals—people or things.

Plural noun When more than one person or thing is being described.

Suffix An ending made up of one or more letters that is added to a word to change its form—for example, from singular to plural.